

THE NDA'S FOUR-PRONGED STRATEGY

...as explained by a top BJP poll campaign leader

- **Communication** Building and deepening connections with allies
- **Widen social base** Expanding reach to cover a larger social rainbow
- **High turnout** Ensuring support base came out to vote, not just for party men but also for allies
- **Star campaigner** Use PM Modi's image to contrast with opponents' 'misgovernance', promise better delivery

THE SOCIAL ALLIANCE

The BJP also brought clarity on two fundamental issues early on. One, it enunciated a clear stand on the caste-based census, helping it retain its clout among the forward castes. By declaring its intent on caste enumeration in the upcoming national census, the party denied the Mahagathbandhan (MGB) the narrative that it was opposed to caste-based reservation. The party also effectively curtailed dissent among Rajput leaders, especially Rajiv Pratap Rudy, and won over actor-politician Pawan Singh. The party fielded 49 candidates from among the forward castes and 40 from the backward communities. The remaining 12 candidates were Dalits. Those who didn't fall in line, like former Union minister R.K. Singh with his post-poll allegations, were shown the door.

This level of coordination stood in stark contrast with the lack of cohesion in the MGB, which ended up fielding rival candidates against each other in 11 seats. The Opposition parties also showed little interest in calibrating candidates with the social geography of the constituencies, filling their quota with little regard for who was best placed to win where. The result was an absence of ground synergy, the very opposite of the NDA's tightly welded machinery. Even the Congress's 'vote chori' allegations failed to get traction in such an environment.

The NDA strategy to not engage and keep the narrative focused elsewhere also deflated the Opposition's charges.

A top BJP leader explained the four-pronged poll strategy in Bihar—build and deepen communication with allies; expand reach to newer bases so as to create a larger social rainbow; ensure high turnout of support base not just for party candidates but also allies; and use Prime Minister Narendra Modi's image to highlight the alleged misgovernance of opponents while also promising better, efficient delivery.

A classic case study of the NDA's winning poll strategy unfolded in the Magadh–Shahabad region, a terrain that had long been the NDA's Achilles' heel. An RJD-Left stronghold for decades, the NDA won 39 of the 48 assembly seats in the zone, a strike rate of 81.2 per cent, in contrast to eight in 2020. Of the MGB's implosion from 110 to 35 seats, 33 of those losses can be traced to this single region. "Every message, every intervention," says Prof. Swadeshi Singh of the Political Science department in Delhi University, "was designed to reinforce the perception of delivery and discipline. This has helped the BJP build what I call a governance-based social alliance. The poll results show how this alliance can transcend older caste and communal boundaries."

MAKING HISTORY

The result was nothing short of transformative. For the first time, the BJP emerged as the single largest party in a state it had never ruled. The NDA won 202 of Bihar's 243 seats. The BJP managed to marry a narrative about progress, continuity and a Modi-Nitish 'double engine' to one that, conversely, revived anxieties about disorder, loosely gathered under the old fear of RJD's 'jungle raj'. A subliminal suggestion that a volte face could return Bihar to a lawless past became a prompt for risk aversion. When presented with two choices—a tested, if imperfect, administration that delivers benefits, or a passionate outsider promising wholesale change—a significant slice of the electorate chose the familiar.

Today, when the victory math is added up, the NDA's vote share has touched 46.5 per cent—up from 37.2 in 2020. While the BJP vote share saw a marginal increase (19.5 to 20.1 per cent), the JD(U) jumped almost four points (15.4 to 19.3 per cent). In fact, the JD(U) executed its strategy well, keeping the emphasis on its governance record, and delivery of welfare schemes. Rahul Verma, political scientist and fellow at the Centre for Policy Research (CPR), says, "The BJP is now the elder brother in coalitions, not only taking the onus of running the campaign but also ensuring that the strike rate of partners stays high. To borrow a cricketing analogy, both batters at the crease have to score for a big total—you can't have a Sehwag at one end and someone who isn't rotating the strike at the other." What's important to ensure a historic victory, as the NDA *jodi* showed, was to play as a team and not as individual stars and to never take your eyes off the ball. ■